

Discovery Booms. Checkout Lags.

AI agents send shoppers to stores, and those shoppers buy. Agents that buy on their own are still rare. Crypto payments for agents exist, and the volume is small.

PART 1 · PAGES 2 TO 11

The Market

Who is winning, what stalled, what people trust, and what the forecasts claim.

\$1B+

a year through Instinct,
per its founder.
Unaudited.

+60%

conversion lift for
shoppers arriving from
AI (Adobe).

PART 2 · PAGES 12 TO 18

Crypto & Stablecoins

How agents pay with crypto today, and why the big numbers shrink.

\$15M

total cleaned x402
volume since May 2025
(Visa, Artemis).

40x

how far the most quoted
x402 figure overstates it.

HOW TO READ THE COLORS



Verified or reported data



Claims, forecasts or inflated figures



Context

The Market

Agents are already a strong way to find products. Very few purchases happen inside the agent yet.

\$10B

Instinct's valuation, 33 days after it was \$2.5B.

3x

Shopify AI-driven orders vs last year, Q2 2026.

~30

merchants went live on ChatGPT checkout before OpenAI pulled back.

11%

most consumers willing to let AI make a buying decision (Gartner).

IN THIS PART

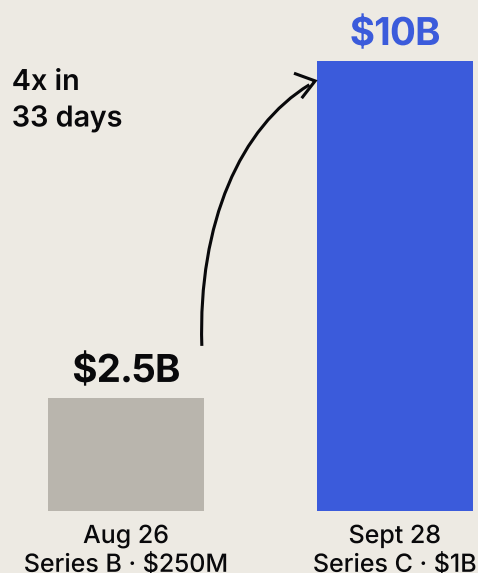
- 03 Instinct Claims \$1B+
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Instinct Claims \$1B+

A two-month-old consumer agent says \$1B a year flows through it. The funding is confirmed. The volume has no audit.

VALUATION, \$B (CONFIRMED)



CONFIRMED

- \$1B Series C at a \$10B valuation from Sequoia, Benchmark and Coatue
- 100,000+ users by mid-September (The Information)
- 14 employees; launched invite-only in August 2026

FOUNDER CLAIM, NO AUDIT

- Over \$1B a year in user spending flows through the agent
- Growing about 10% a day, with no marketing spend
- More than half of volume is travel

GUT-CHECK MATH

\$10K

per user per year. That is \$1B spread across 100,000 users. Possible for wealthy travelers, but high.

17x

per month. That is what 10% daily growth compounds to. It describes a short early burst.

HOW TO CITE IT

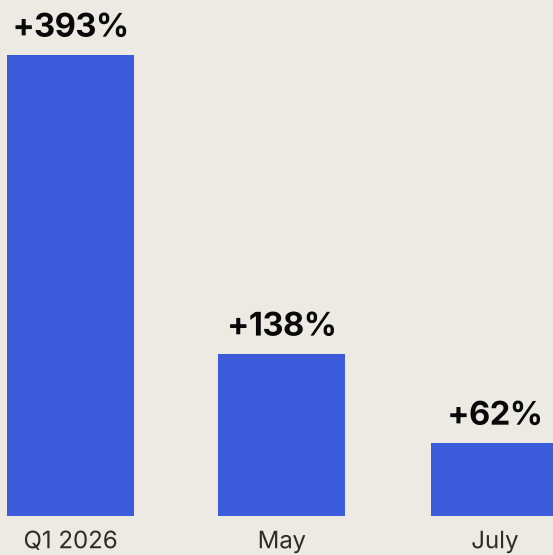
"Instinct's founder says \$1B+ a year in transactions flows through the agent (podcast, Sept 28, 2026; unaudited)." No revenue is disclosed.

Sources: Business Wire, Reuters, TechCrunch (Sept 28 to 30, 2026); Skift (Sept 28); The Information (Sept 15); Patrick O'Shaughnessy podcast (Sept 28).

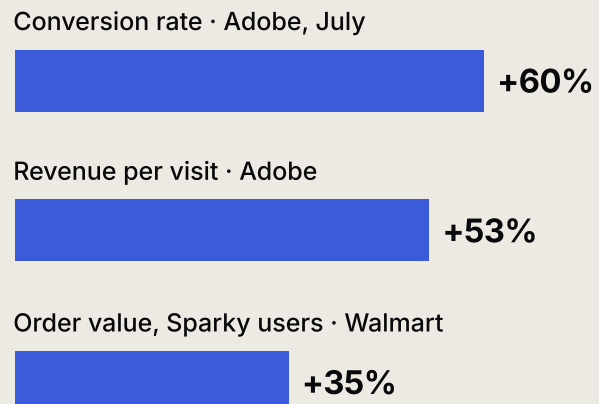
Discovery Is Working

Shoppers who arrive from AI convert better and spend more per visit.
Traffic growth is cooling as the base gets bigger.

AI REFERRAL TRAFFIC TO US RETAIL, GROWTH VS LAST YEAR



LIFT VS OTHER SHOPPERS



SCALE OF THE SHIFT

3x

Shopify AI-driven orders vs last year (Q2). Shopify still calls it "small."

75%

of Shopify AI orders come from outside its top 100 categories.

~50M

shopping queries a day in ChatGPT, about 2% of prompts.

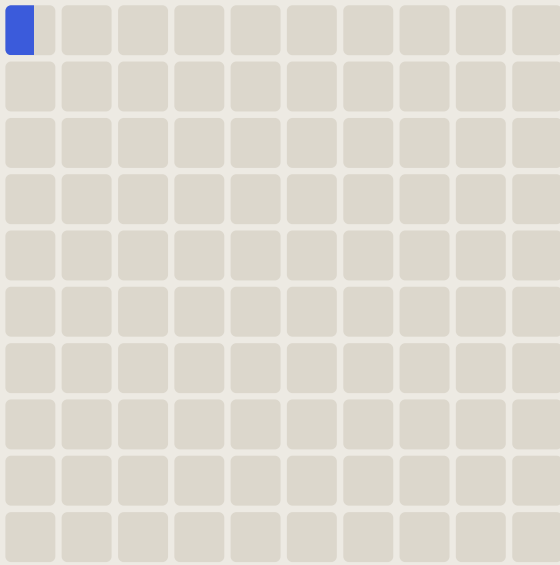
What it means: AI is becoming the front door for product search. Most of these shoppers still finish the purchase on the merchant's own site.

Sources: Adobe Digital Insights (Q1, May and July 2026 data); Shopify Q2 2026 call (Aug 5); Walmart Q1 FY27 call (May 21, 2026); OpenAI and David Deming study.

Checkout Has Stalled

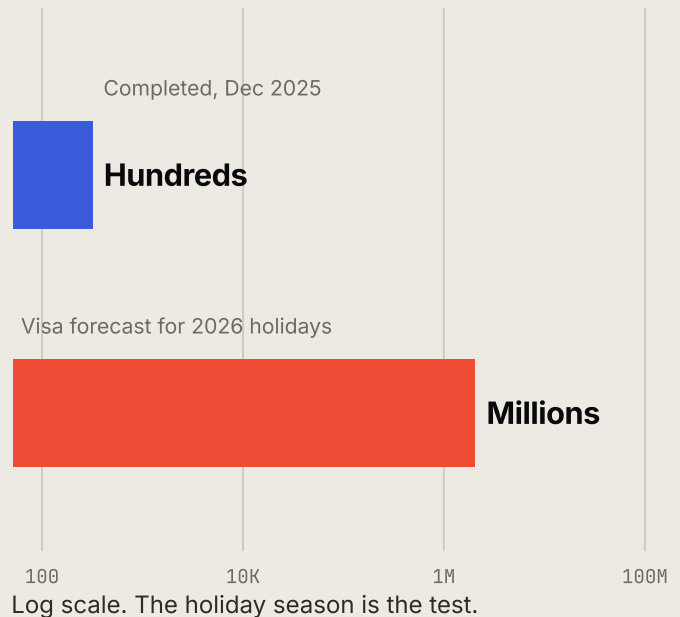
Buying inside the AI app keeps underperforming. People click through and pay on the merchant's site instead.

BOOKING ROOM NIGHTS FROM AI CHATBOTS



Under 1% of 100 squares. Booking calls it "significantly below 1%" (Q2 2026).

VISA AGENT TRANSACTIONS



THE RETREAT

~30

Shopify merchants live on ChatGPT Instant Checkout, out of 1M+ eligible (Feb 2026).

3x

lower conversion for Walmart inside ChatGPT than on its own site.

Mar '26

OpenAI moved Instant Checkout into apps. Merchants now run their own checkout.

Expedia says agentic traffic "remains small." The pattern holds across retail and travel: discover in AI, buy on site.

Sources: Forrester via CNBC (Mar 20, 2026); Visa release (Dec 18, 2025); Booking Holdings Q2 call (Aug 4, 2026); Expedia Q2 2026 call; Walmart via CNBC.

A Year of Big Moves

Launches, retreats and lawsuits show who is pushing into agent shopping and who is walling it off.



Sources: CNBC, Bloomberg, GeekWire, PYMNTS, Google blog, Stripe blog, Visa, Reuters, TechCrunch (Sept 2025 to Sept 2026).

Too Many Standards

At least eight protocols compete to define how agents shop and pay. Card networks and Ant International began aligning in September.

1 Find & check out

What the agent reads and orders from

ACP

OpenAI + Stripe

UCP

Google, Shopify, Walmart, Target

MCP

The plug that connects agents to store and wallet tools across every layer

2 Authorize payment

Proving the agent may pay for this person

AP2

Google

TAP

Visa

Agent Pay

Mastercard

ACE

Amex

3 Settle payments

Small payments between software

x402

Coinbase + Cloudflare

MPP

Stripe + Tempo

1 for 4

Visa's Intelligent Commerce Connect gives merchants one integration for four protocols.

Feeds first

For merchants, being readable by agents pays today: clean live product feeds and Shopify Agentic Storefronts.

Sources: Google blog (Jan 2026); Stripe Sessions (Apr 29, 2026); Visa (Apr 2026); Mastercard (Apr 2025 to Jun 2026); Coinbase; Tether (Sept 2026).

Shoppers Want Control

Most people have used AI to shop. Few let it pay without asking. Fear of fraud is the top reason.

SHARE OF CONSUMERS (SEPARATE SURVEYS)

Have used an AI assistant

Visa

72%

Let AI complete a purchase

Menlo, AI-using shoppers

26%

Trust AI with payments

Visa

23%

Would let AI decide on low-stakes buys, at most

Gartner

11%

Would let an agent shop fully on its own

Accenture

9%

WHAT THEY WANT INSTEAD

64%

won't let AI spend without approval (Spredly).

52%

name fear of fraud as the reason (Spredly).

32%

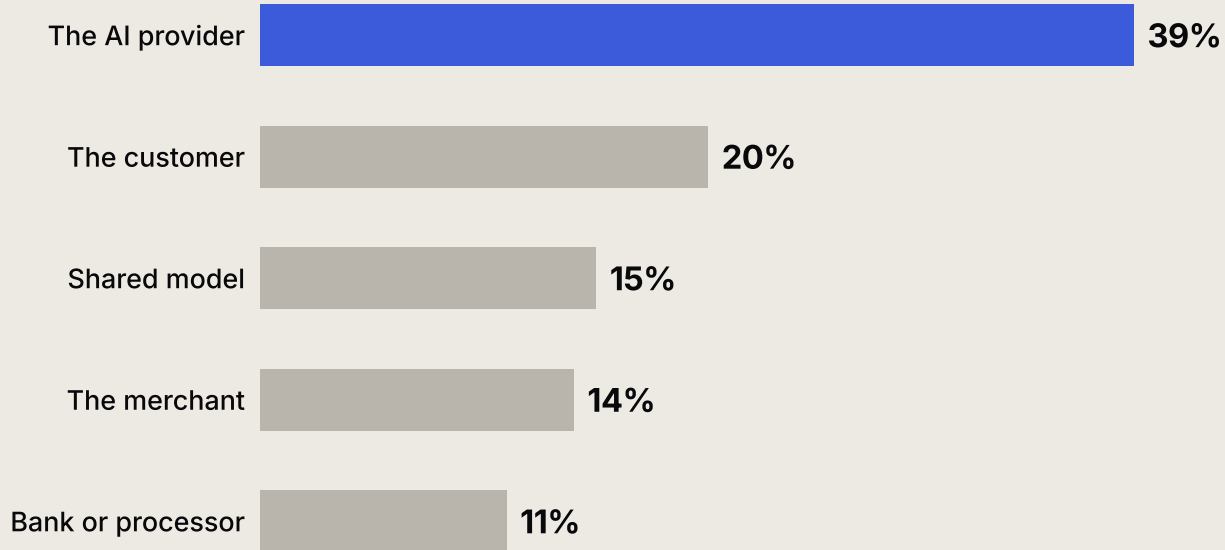
would allow agent buying within set limits (Accenture).

Sources: Visa Trust Index (Sept 2026); Menlo Ventures (2026); Gartner survey of 322 US consumers (May 27, 2026); Accenture (25,590 consumers); Spredly (Sept 30, 2026).

Who Pays Is Unclear

When an agent buys the wrong thing, no network rule says who takes the loss. Bot fraud is already climbing.

WHO SHOULD PAY FOR A BAD AGENT PURCHASE? FRAUD LEADERS SAY:



Clean fraud on card tokens is settled: the issuer carries it and the cardholder keeps chargeback rights. The gray zone is an agent that did what it was told, badly.

FRAUD SIGNALS

+25%

malicious bot-initiated transactions in six months; +40% in the US (Visa).

324M

chargebacks a year by 2028, up 24% from 2025 (Datos forecast).

+50%

automated fraud attacks after ChatGPT Agent launched (Forter).

Sources: Darwinium survey of 500 fraud leaders; Worldpay (2026); Visa; Forter; Datos Insights.

Work and Travel Lead

Procurement agents run in production at hundreds of companies. Travel is the top consumer use. Neither reports agent-driven dollars.

B2B AND PROCUREMENT

450+

Coupa customers running its agents in production

50+

Zip agents live across hundreds of enterprises

50K+

Ramp customers covered by agent bill pay on Visa rails

90%

of B2B buying "agent intermediated" by 2028, \$15T+ (Gartner forecast)

TRAVEL

>50%

of Instinct's claimed volume is travel

<1%

of Booking room nights come from AI chatbots

10

hotel partners in Google AI Mode booking, incl. Marriott and Expedia

\$3.0B

Navan quarterly bookings, +45%. Its AI handles about 60% of support

Note the word "intermediated" in Gartner's forecast. It covers agents that help with a purchase, not only agents that complete one.

Sources: Gartner (Oct 21, 2025); Ramp (Apr 2026); Coupa (Aug 2026); Zip (June 2026); Booking and Expedia Q2 2026 calls; Navan Q2 FY27; Google (Aug 27, 2026).

Forecasts Span 26x

2030 estimates run from \$190B to \$5T because each firm counts "agentic" differently. Near-term numbers match what we actually see.

AGENTIC COMMERCE SIZE, \$B, LOG SCALE



\$8B to \$21B

Near-term 2026 estimates. These fit the traction we can see.

> \$500B?

Treat 2030 numbers above this as scenarios unless the source defines "agentic."

Sources: McKinsey (Oct 2025); Morgan Stanley (Nov 2025); Bain; Juniper (Apr 2026); eMarketer (Dec 2025); Gartner.

Crypto Rails

Agents do pay with stablecoins. Almost all of it is pennies for API calls, and the big numbers are inflated.

\$15M

cleaned x402 volume, total since May 2025.

14¢

average cleaned x402 payment.

~50%

of x402 activity was artificial (CoinDesk).

-93%

x402 daily volume so far in 2026.

IN THIS PART

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- 14 Payments Are Pennies
- 15 Cards Carry the Money

- 16 Why Cards Win Checkout
- 17 Both Rails Get Built
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Big Numbers Shrink 40x

The x402 figure people quote most is about 40x the cleaned total.
Always ask whether a number is raw or adjusted.

X402 VOLUME, \$M (DIFFERENT MEASURES SHOWN SIDE BY SIDE)

Annualized figure quoted in blogs

Mar 2026, a run-rate estimate



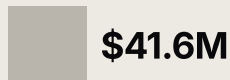
Raw on-chain total since May 2025

178M transactions, Visa and Artemis



Settlement tracker, flat since April

On-chain tracker



Cleaned total, junk removed

110M transactions, Visa and Artemis



~50%

of x402 activity was artificial, per
CoinDesk (Mar 2026).

-93%

x402 daily volume so far this
year, per the tracker.

9x

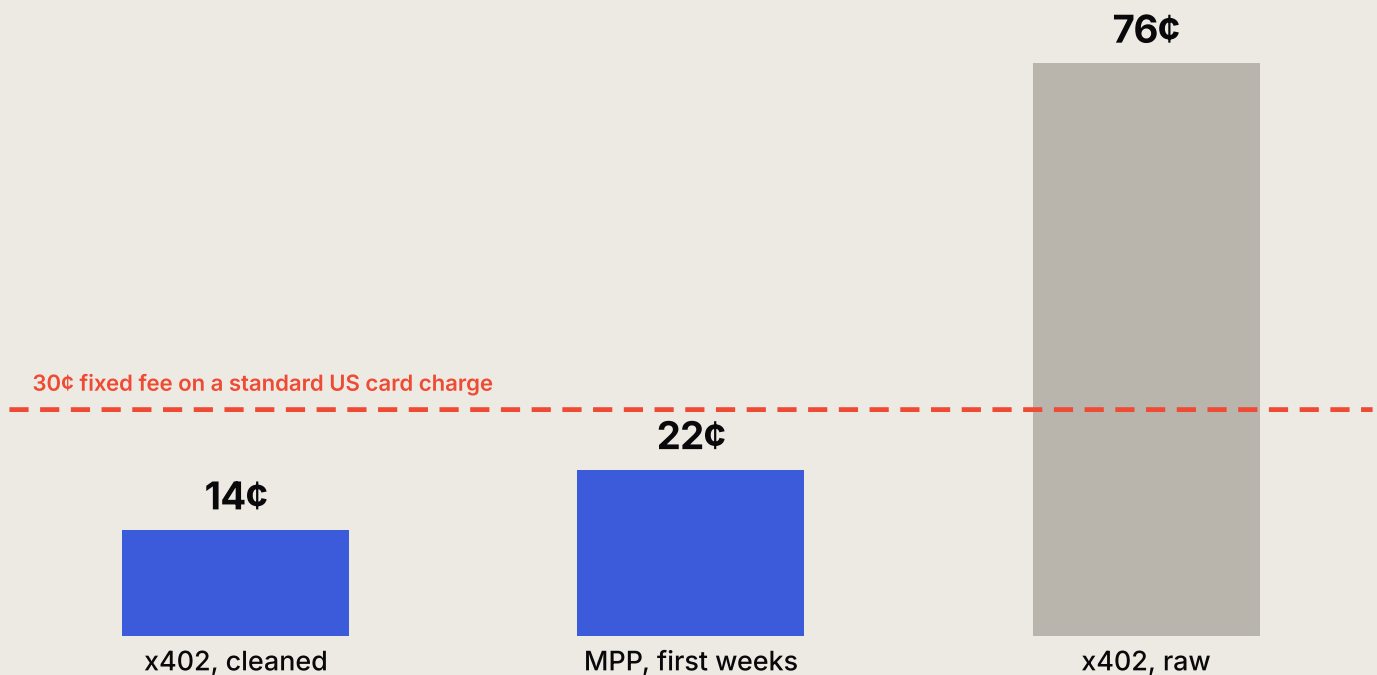
gap between raw and cleaned
totals measured the same way.

Sources: Visa and Artemis report (July 2026); CoinDesk (Mar 2026); x402 settlement tracker; blog estimates (Mar 2026).

Payments Are Pennies

Cleaned agent crypto payments average 14 cents. A standard card charge carries a 30-cent fixed fee, more than the payment itself.

AVERAGE PAYMENT SIZE, CENTS



WHAT AGENTS BUY WITH CRYPTO

Machine to machine

Per-call API access, data feeds, content and crawling. Software paying software in amounts cards can't handle well.

Rarely people's purchases

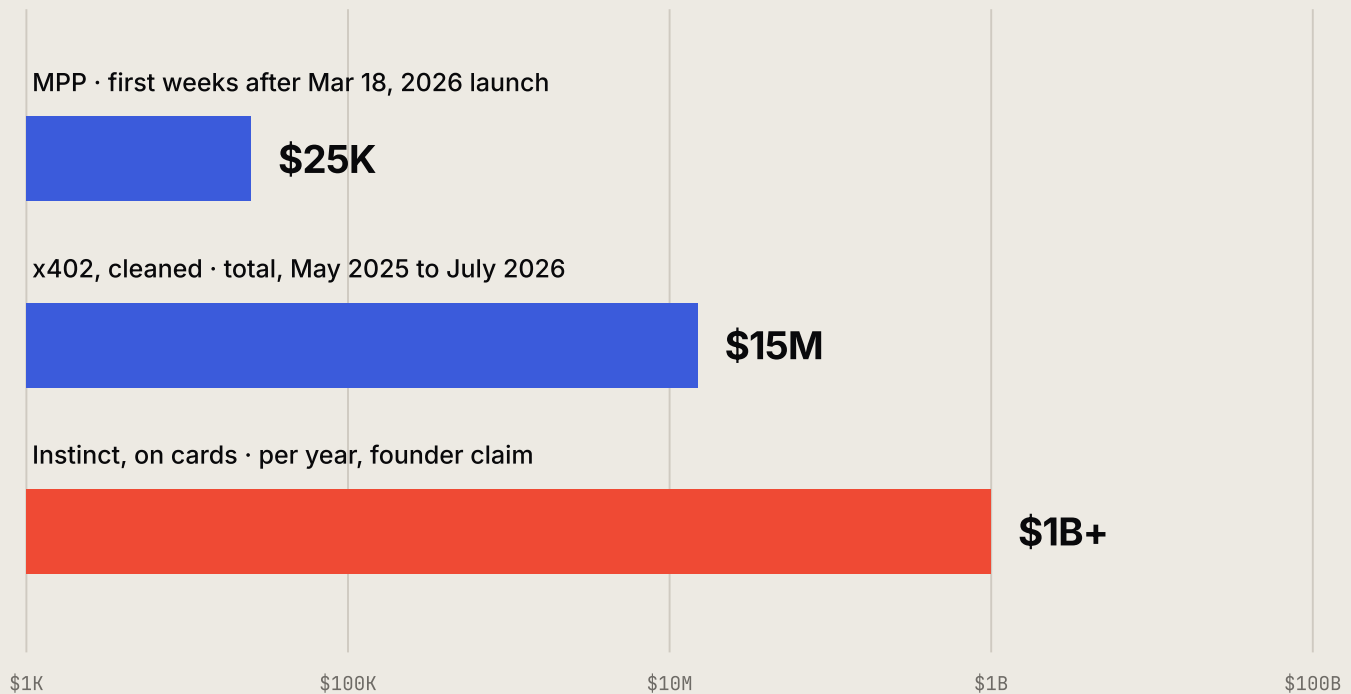
No sign of meaningful shoe, grocery or hotel buying on these rails. Those run on cards and wallets.

Sources: Visa and Artemis (July 2026); Stripe and Tempo MPP early data; Stripe US pricing page (2.9% + 30¢, checked Oct 2, 2026).

Cards Carry the Money

One card-based consumer agent claims more volume in a year than all cleaned x402 traffic since 2025, by about 67x.

DOLLAR VOLUME, LOG SCALE (BASES DIFFER, SEE LABELS)



HOW AGENTS PAY AT CHECKOUT TODAY

Meta Muse

One-time Stripe virtual cards

Visa and Mastercard

Agent card tokens with spending rules

Stripe Link

Agent wallet for 200M+ Link users

Shop Pay, PayPal, Google Pay

Wallets inside Gemini, Muse and Shopify

Sources: Instinct founder (Sept 28, 2026, unaudited); Visa and Artemis (July 2026); Stripe and Tempo MPP; Meta Connect (Sept 2026); Stripe Sessions (Apr 2026).

Why Cards Win Checkout

Cards give a buyer recourse when an agent gets it wrong. Stablecoins win on tiny, instant payments, and offer no easy dispute process.

	Cards	Stablecoins
Chargebacks and disputes	☒ Yes	☐ No
Fraud liability rules	☒ Yes	☐ No
Agent identity built in	☒ Yes	☒ Partly
Purchase protection	☒ Yes	☐ No
Payments under a few cents	☐ No	☒ Yes
Instant global settlement	☒ Partly	☒ Yes

WHY IT MATTERS

52%

of consumers cite fear of fraud as why they won't let AI spend freely (Spredly).

First

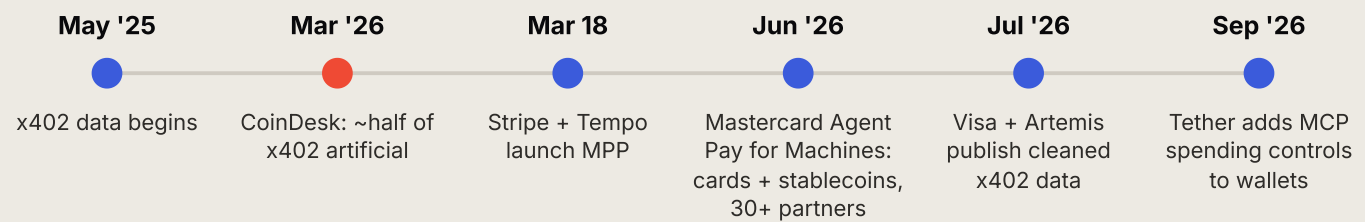
Amex ACE offers what it calls the first purchase protection for agent buys.

Sources: Worldpay (2026); Visa and Mastercard agent programs; Amex ACE; Spredly (Sept 30, 2026); research synthesis.

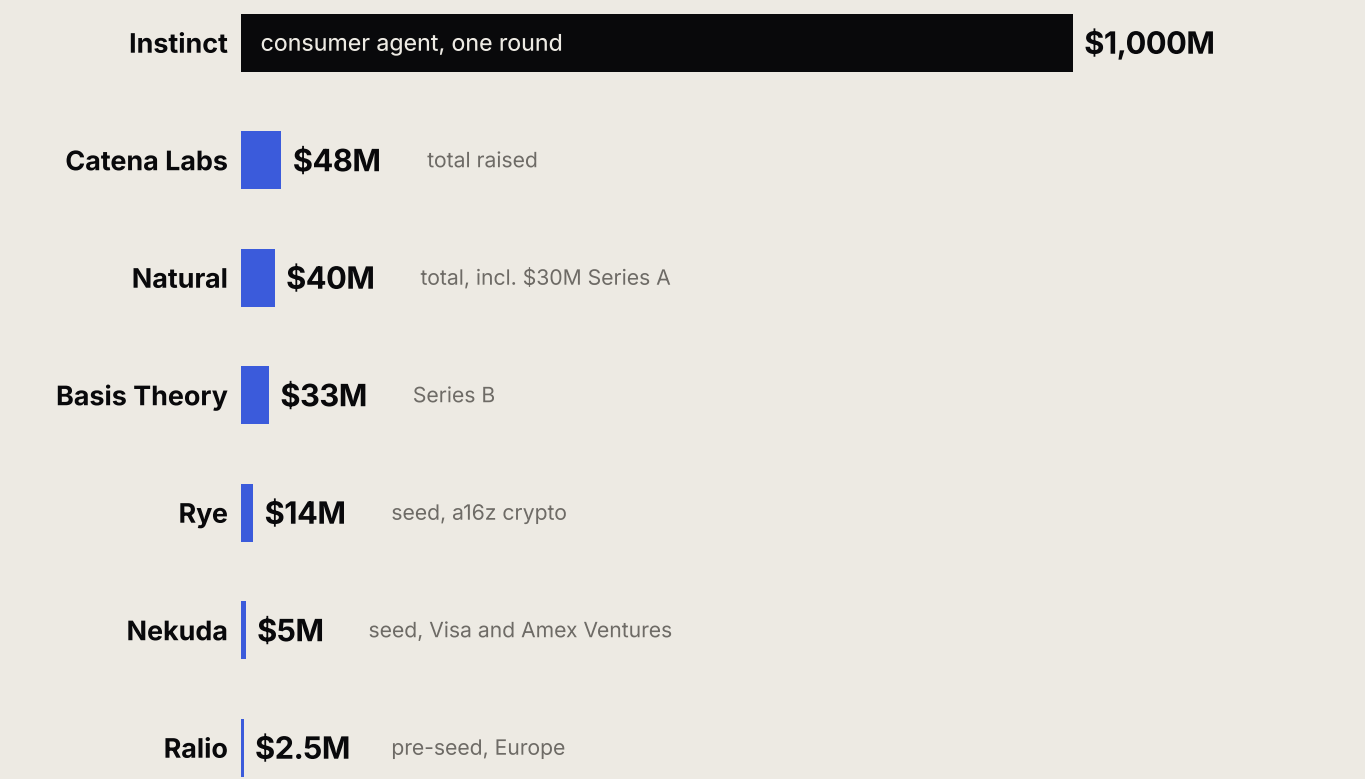
Both Rails Get Built

Networks and stablecoin issuers ship agent tools for cards and crypto.
None publishes crypto agent volume. Startup checks stay small.

CRYPTO AGENT PAYMENTS TIMELINE



REPORTED FUNDING, \$M



Sources: Coinbase; CoinDesk; Stripe; Mastercard (June 2026); Visa and Artemis; Tether (Sept 2026); funding: company releases, Trio, FinTech Global (2026).

Narrow Fit, Real Upside

Stablecoins fit tiny machine-to-machine payments. Cards fit purchases where a person needs recourse. Our read of the research.



The stablecoin zone could grow fast as agents multiply. Today it is tiny. Watch cleaned x402 volume and whether any network publishes crypto agent numbers.

Sources: Synthesis of this report's sources. Placement is judgment.

What to Watch

Six signals will show whether agent buying is going mainstream. Plus four questions to ask of any number you see.

01**Holiday 2026**

Does Visa's "millions of agent shoppers" show up? Do Adobe and Salesforce start counting agent-completed sales on their own?

02**Consumer super-agents**

Instinct, Meta Muse and Wajo race to own "do it for me." Look for real user and revenue numbers.

03**Amazon vs open agents**

The Perplexity case after the Ninth Circuit ruling, and Amazon's block on Muse.

04**Discover in AI, buy on site**

If checkout stays with merchants, AI companies make money from discovery and ads.

05**Liability rules**

Network or regulator rules for "my agent bought the wrong thing" disputes.

06**Stablecoin volume**

Cleaned x402 growth, and whether any network publishes agent crypto volume.

ASK OF ANY NUMBER

Raw or adjusted?

x402: 9x to 40x apart

Total or annualized?

Run rates inflate young products

Influenced, referred or completed?

Salesforce's \$67B is "influenced"

Audited or founder-stated?

Instinct's \$1B is a podcast claim

Sources: this report. Forward-looking items are judgment, not forecasts.

Sources

INSTINCT

TechCrunch, Instinct founder said more than 50% of transactions are travel-related (Sept 29, 2026)
TechCrunch, Instinct's new product recommendations (Sept 30, 2026)
Skift, Instinct's app is fueled by travel (Sept 28, 2026)
FourWeekMBA, Tech Funding News, AI Weekly on the \$1B Series C (Sept 2026)

DISCOVERY AND CHECKOUT

Adobe Digital Insights via Digital Commerce 360 (Aug 19, 2026) and Yahoo Finance (Q1 2026)
Shopify Q2 2026 earnings call transcript (Motley Fool, Aug 2026)
Walmart Q1 FY27 call; Retail Dive on Sparky
CNBC, OpenAI's first try at agentic shopping stumbled (Mar 20, 2026)
Visa, Visa and partners complete secure AI transactions (Dec 18, 2025)
Booking Holdings and Expedia Q2 2026 earnings calls; Navan Q2 FY27 results

PLATFORMS AND STANDARDS

Google blog, NRF 2026 remarks and agentic commerce tools (Jan 2026)
Stripe, Everything we announced at Sessions 2026 (Apr 29, 2026)
Bloomberg, CNBC, GeekWire, PYMNTS on Amazon vs Perplexity (Nov 2025 to Aug 2026)
Mastercard newsroom on Agent Pay in Europe and Latin America (2026)
PPC Land on Google AI Mode hotel booking (Aug 2026)

CONSUMERS, RISK, FORECASTS

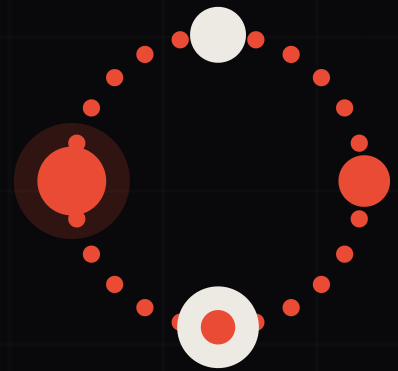
Gartner consumer survey (May 27, 2026) and predictions (Oct 21, 2025)
Accenture consumer research; Menlo Ventures State of Consumer AI 2026
Webscale, The Chai newsletter (Sept 2026) for Spreadly and Visa Trust Index data
Worldpay, Agentic commerce liability is still being written; Justt; FraudBeat
Salesforce Cyber Week data (Dec 5, 2025); McKinsey, Morgan Stanley, Bain, Juniper, eMarketer

CRYPTO AND STABLECOINS

Visa, Agentic payments: what onchain data reveals (with Artemis, July 2026)
Daniel McGlynn, x402 volume numbers are wrong (2026); Blockchain.news, x402 settlements flat
minddog, agentic-commerce-research paper (MPP and CoinDesk figures)
Genfinity and PYMNTS on Mastercard Agent Pay for Machines (June 2026)
Stripe pricing page, checked Oct 2, 2026
Trio, ValueAdd VC, FinTech Global on startup funding (2026)

Figures are as reported by each source. Most traction numbers are company-reported and unaudited. Compiled October 2, 2026.

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